

Warning signs

There are some common signs to look out for that may indicate a person has an eating disorder:

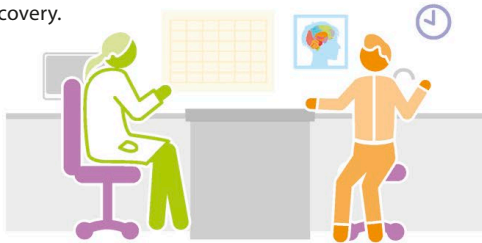
- Rapid weight loss, or frequent weight changes.
- Disordered eating behaviors, such as eating very little or excessively.
- Repeated weighing and obsessive calorie counting.
- Refusing to eat with other people or in public.
- Saying negative things about the body.
- Feeling tired or low energy.
- Wearing baggy or oversize clothing to hide the body.
- Extreme exercise habits.
- Secretive behavior or disappearing to the bathroom after meals.

Seeking help

The health problems caused by eating disorders can be fatal if left untreated, so it's essential to address the issue as soon as possible. Helping a loved one can be a challenge, especially if they are in denial or act defensively. After seeing a doctor, it may be necessary for them to be referred to a specialized eating disorders clinic for further support.

▷ First steps

Seeing a doctor is the first step toward treatment and recovery.



GOOD TO KNOW

Helping a loved one

- Stay calm and avoid passing judgement, blame, or criticism. Instead, build their self-esteem with praise.
- Try not to be pushy with advice—rather, ask what support they need. Talk to them about how they feel.
- Be prepared for the person to reject help or to respond negatively.
- Avoid talking about appearance or weight in front of them.
- Keep trying to include the person in activities, even if they don't want to socialize.
- Encourage them to get professional help, either through their doctor or by calling a helpline.

Treatment

Eating disorders often disguise other problems, such as anxiety, depression, or feelings of isolation. Consequently, treating an eating disorder is not simply about helping a person reach a healthy weight. It also involves addressing the underlying emotional and psychological issues behind the behavior. Recovery can be a slow process as the person with an eating disorder gradually rebuilds their relationship with food and the body. Some people may relapse, but with the right support and time, eating disorders can be successfully treated.



△ Treatment methods

Treatments differ for everybody, but can include medication, counseling, or family therapy.